

SHRINE EMPIRE

art exposure

Amitava

A Solo Presentation at Spotlight

FRIEZE MASTERS



AMITAVA

FRIEZE MASTERS 2025

Spotlight curated by Valerie Cassel Oliver

About the Presentation

Amitava Das's practice is defined by preoccupations in India during the insurgencies and uncertainties that a newly formed national context was faced with, with the Cold War looming in the backdrop. Part of a generation that was born in the moment of Independence from colonial rule in 1947, Amitava was already familiar with early anti-colonial and post-independent modernisms in India, as well as post-war art in Europe such as the work of Giacometti, and Surrealism from an early age. These early influences led him to explore his own interiority in the 1960s, when he was an art student. The works that will be featured at Frieze Masters are mostly from the 1970s, and capture a prominent period in his practice that marks a departure from early considerations maintained by his practice to look outwards at the complex interrelations between the human experience and the world around. In this endeavour of contemplating external realities, two strands of work emerge as significant propositions by the artist in the 1970s. On one hand he frequently returned to his childhood in the idyllic landscape of Shimla, with its mountainscapes, greenery and creaturely existences, situating human existences as enmeshed with, and even corporeally constituted of the natural and more than human, animate and inanimate, lifeforms around them, in concurrence with the global rise of ecological consciousness in the decade. Another simultaneous body of work poetically responds to the politics of the time in a Soviet leaning, Non-Aligned nation state, that did not know whether to turn right or left, caught between the allure of capitalist consumerism and the romantic ideals that fuel revolutions. These works unconsciously draw from his awareness of student movements, protest cultures, the revival of Che Guera in the public imagination, and the poetry of Jibananda Das and Shakti Chattopadhyay.

Bio

Amitava (b.1947) lives and works in New Delhi. He graduated from the Delhi College of Art in 1972. Amitava has been strongly influenced by the existential philosophy of Sartre and Camus as well as the poetry of Jibananda Das and Shakti Chattopadhyay. The existential dilemma of a man thrown into a world as a stranger is characteristic of his work. The existential dilemma of a man thrown into a world as a stranger is characteristic of his work. In his paintings, Amitava introduces a single figure within a dense, turgidly rendered space. His work is primarily based on human situations, where man is both the creator and the destroyer.



The natural and artificial are cleverly fused to show the interdependence of the man-made and natural worlds. He tries to bring out the inner struggles of men placed in difficult times. From the gentleness and resignation in his earlier works, he moved on to canvases that depict the violence and avarice of modern times. Working with a variety of mediums, Amitava uses watercolours, oils, and pastels to portray his thoughts and feelings evoked by his observations of the life around him. In the 70s, Amitava co-founded the New Group, a Delhi-based artists' collective. He taught art at Jamia Millia Islamia (1974-75) and was a visiting faculty member of College of Art and Women's Polytechnic, Delhi (1977).

Amitava has designed publications, exhibitions, interiors, furniture and created trade fair graphics. He has been profiled in A Painter's Portrait, a film by K. Bikram Singh for Doordarshan, and featured in numerous other television programmes. He co-curated the contemporary Indian art exhibition The Yellow Deity for the National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi, and the Museum of Contemporary Art, Budapest, Hungary.

He has held several solo exhibitions, including In Another Time That is Now at Bikaner House, a collaboration between Shrine Empire and Art Exposure, New Delhi (2024); Come Play With Me at Bagash Art Gallery, Dubai (2006); Galerie FIA, Amsterdam (1997); Sakshi Gallery, Mumbai (1993 and 2004); and Art Heritage, Delhi (1990 and 1996).

His group exhibition history spans decades and continents. Most recently, his work has been featured in India Art Fair (Shrine Empire, 2025), If We Knew the Point at Ki ran Nadar Museum of Art, Delhi (2024), Art Mumbai with Art Exposure (2024), and Miracle of Absence at Art Exposure, Kolkata (2024). In 2024, his works also appeared at the India Art Fair (Shrine Empire). Prior to this, he exhibited in Old Bengal, Modern to Contemporary (Series - I) and Phase - II: Contemporary Practices, both at Gallery Kolkata (2020 and 2019 respectively). His earlier exhibitions include Drawing '94 at Gallery Espace, AIFACS, New Delhi; India Songs - Multiple Streams in Contemporary Indian Art at the Art Gallery of New South Wales, Sydney and Orange Regional Gallery, Australia (1993); Indische Gegenwartskunst in Mainz, Germany, and Stettin, Poland (1993); Contemporary Indian Art in Dhaka, Bangladesh (1992); and Three Contemporary Artists in Bremen, Germany (1991).

In the 1980s, Amitava participated in War and Peace - Contemporary Paintings at Max Mueller Bhavan across Indian metros (1990), Contemporary India Painting in Darmstadt, Germany (1989), the Fredrikstad Biennale of Prints in Norway (1984), Contemporary India Painting in Moscow (1984), Grenchen Triennale - International Exhibition of Prints in Switzerland (1982), Prints at Galerie Steinmetz in Bonn, Germany (1981), and the All India Exhibition of Drawings in Chennai (1981). His earliest major exhibitions include The Pictorial Space, curated by Geeta Kapur at La lit Kala Akademi, New Delhi (1977), and Two Painters - Amitava Das and Manjit Bawa at Black Partridge Gallery, New Delhi (1977).

Amitava received a fellowship from the Federal Republic of Germany in 1989 for advanced exposure to exhibition and graphic design. He was awarded the National Award in 1976 and the Sahitya Kala Parishad Award in 1982. His works are part of significant collections including those of the Society of Contemporary Art, London; National Gallery of Modern Art, Delhi; Bharat Bhawan, Bhopal; Punjab Museum, Chandigarh; and Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi.



Amitava

Untitled 2

Waterproof ink, watercolour and pencil

14 x 10 inches | 35.5 × 25.4 cm

1978

GBP 6850 | INR 750000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 4

Waterproof ink, watercolour and pencil

14 x 10 inches | 35.5 × 25.4 cm

1978

GBP 6850 | INR 750000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Figure in Landscape 2nd
Oil on canvas
48 x 46 inches | 121.9 × 116.8 cm
1979-1980

GBP 25500 | INR 2800000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week

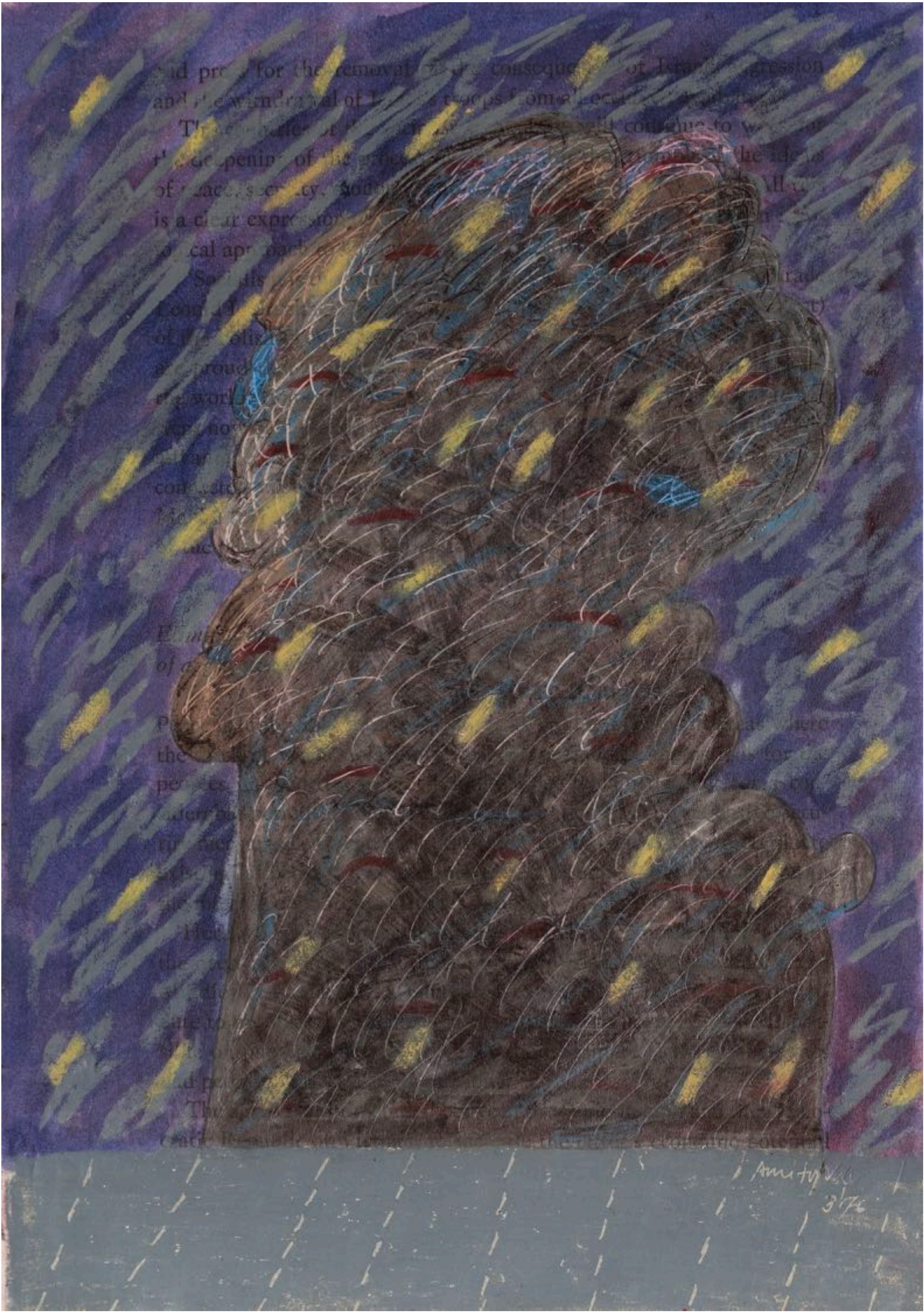


Amitava

Untitled 9
waterproof ink, colour pencil and waterclour
7 x 10 inches | 17.7 × 25.4 cm
1977

GBP 7300 | INR 800000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 6
Oil on canvas
48 x 46 inches | 121.9 × 116.8 cm
1976

GBP 5500 | INR 600000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 7

Ink oil pastel and colour pencil
9.8 x 7 inches | 24.8 × 17.7 cm
1975

GBP 5500 | INR 600000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week

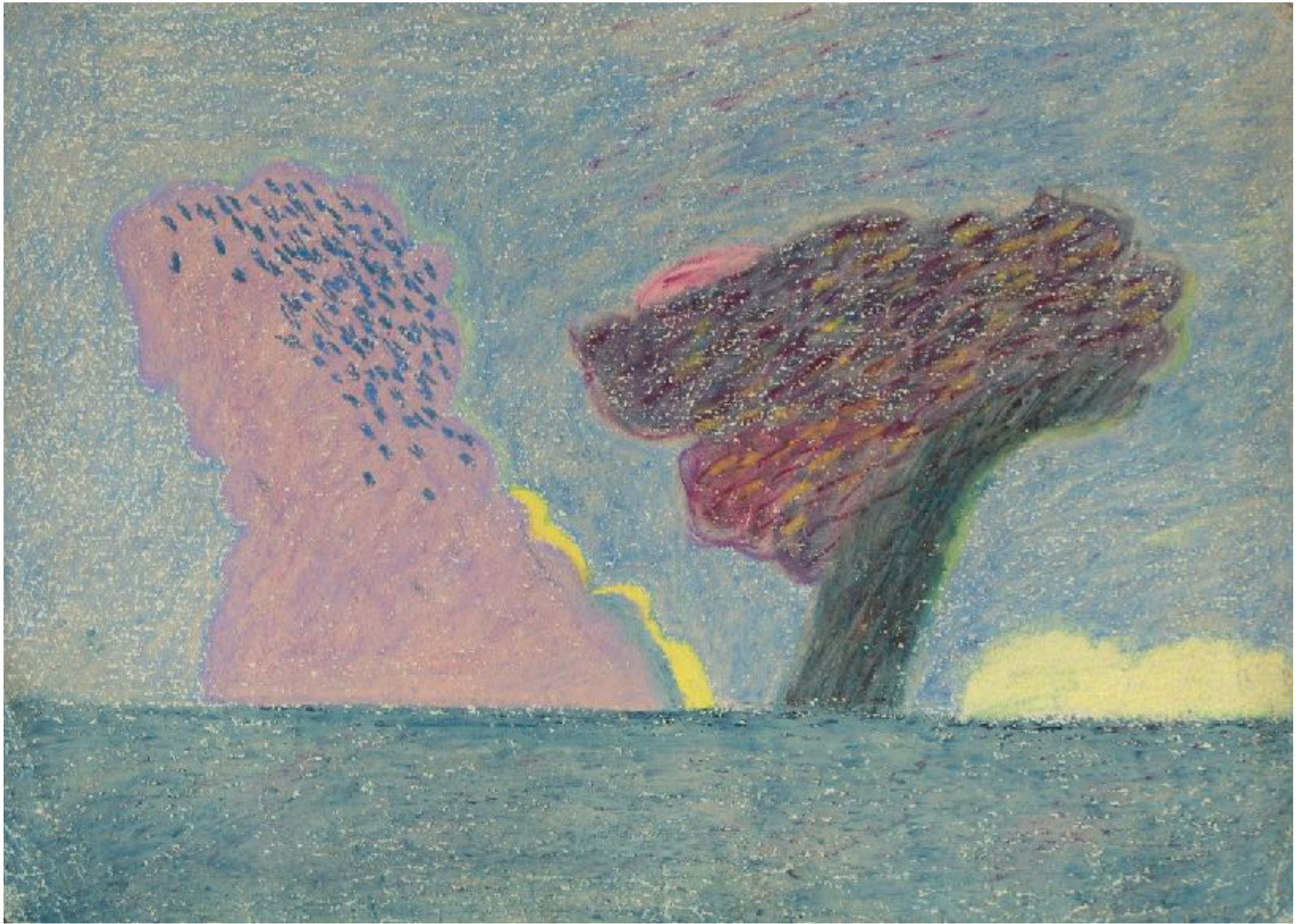


Amitava

Yellow Cloud
Oil on canvas
36 x 36 inches | 91.4 × 91.4 cm
Late 1970s

GBP 22750 | INR 2500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week

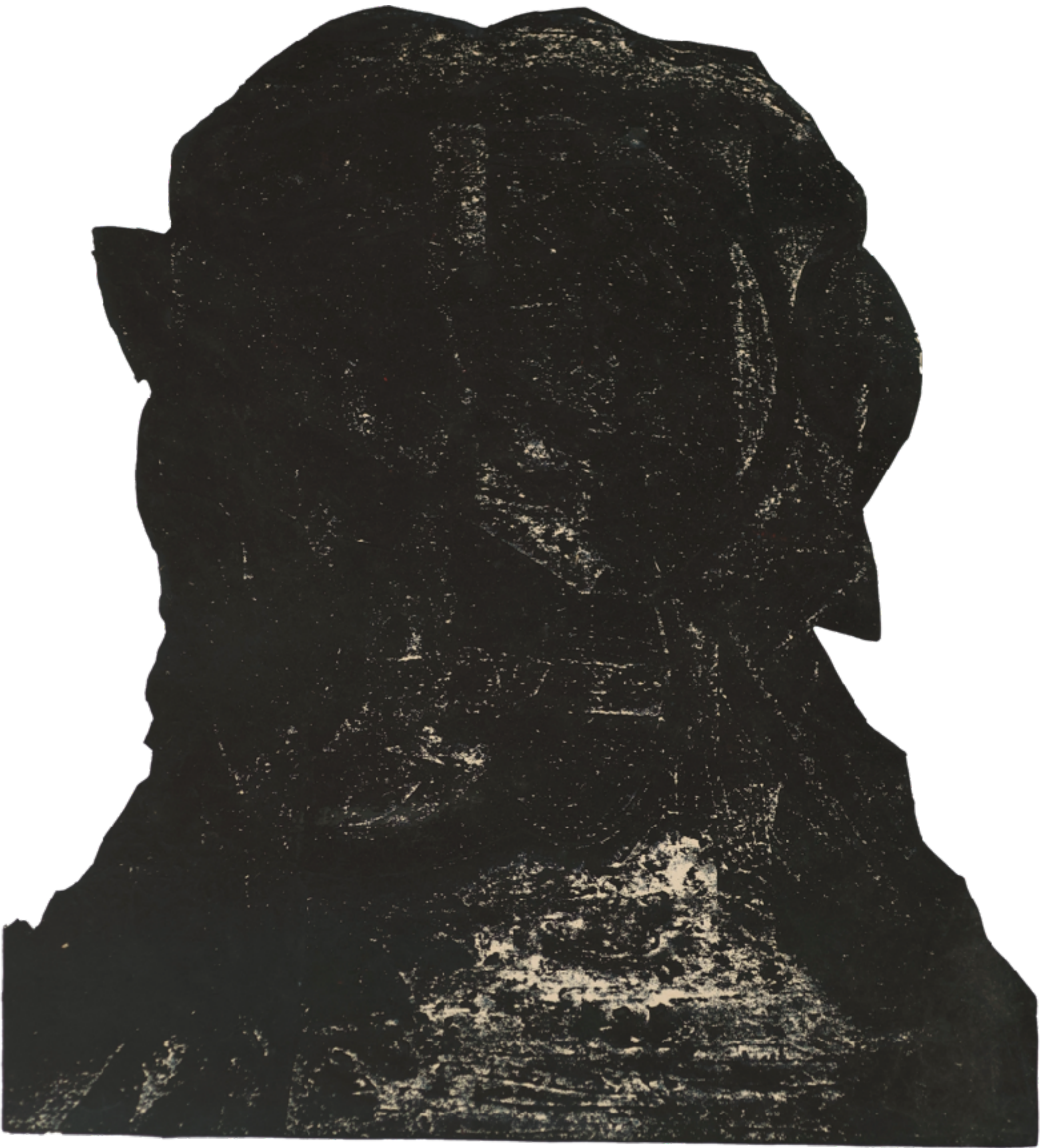


Amitava

Untitled 12
Oil pastel on handmade paper
36 x 36 inches | 91.4 × 91.4 cm
1970

GBP 10950 | INR 1200000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 33
Printing ink
10.4 x 9.1 inches | 26.4 × 23.1 cm
1970

GBP 5000 | INR 550000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 34

Monotype printing ink

12.1 x 11.9 inches | 30.7 × 30.2 cm

1970

GBP 5000 | INR 550000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



[Back](#)

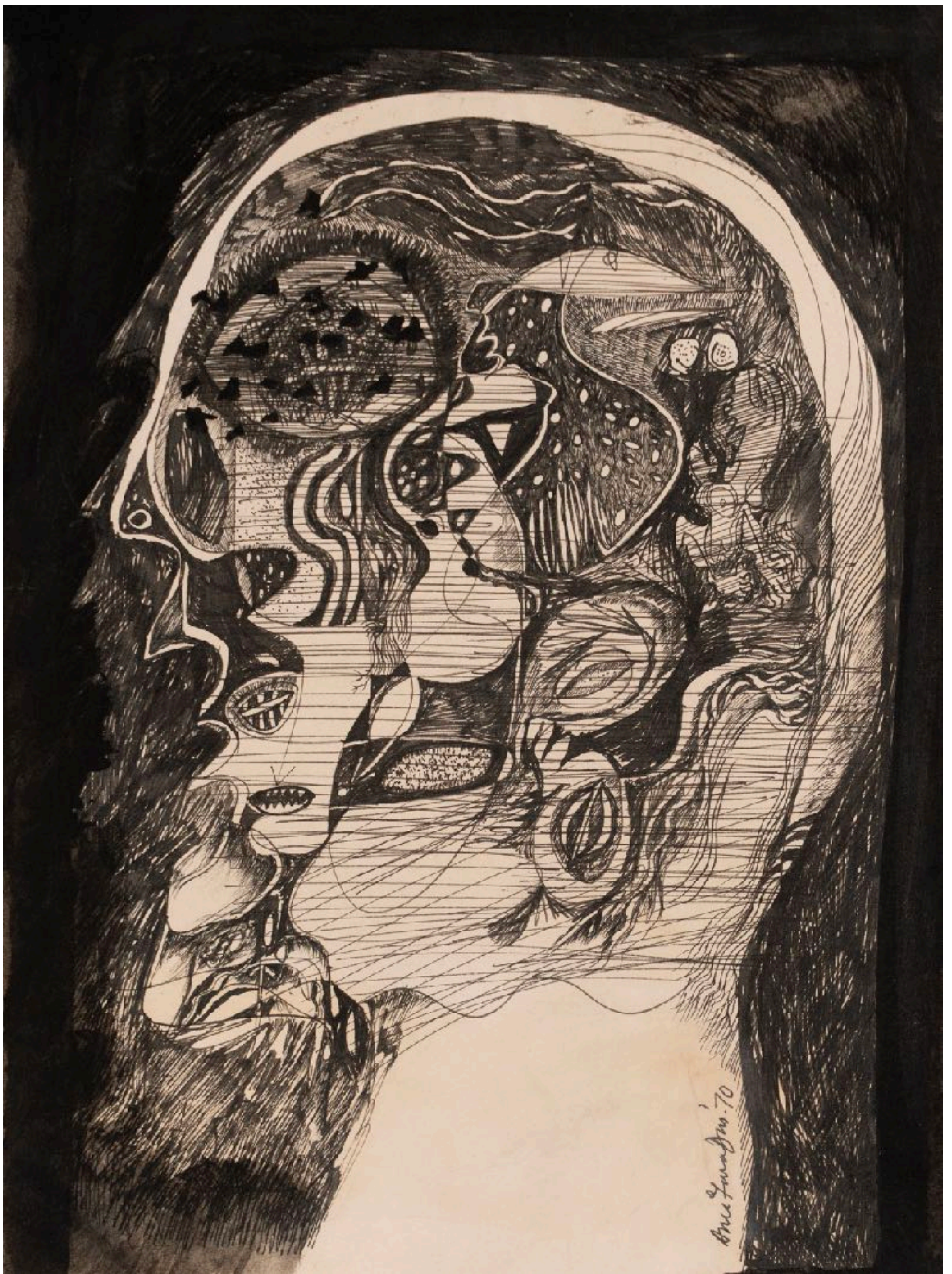


Amitava

Untitled 103
Pen and ink and ink wash
15.1 x 10.1 inches | 38.3 × 25.6 cm
1970

GBP 13650 | INR 1500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 59
Pen and ink
8.3 x 12.5 inches | 21 × 31.7 cm
1970

GBP 7300 | INR 800000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 5

Pen and ink

12 x 8 inches | 30.4 × 20.3 cm

1974

GBP 6850 | INR 750000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 80
Pen and ink
8.9 x 7.4 inches | 22.6 × 18.7 cm
1970

GBP 9100 | INR 1000000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 133

Brown and black pen and ink
20 x 15 inches | 50.8 × 38.1 cm
1969

GBP 13650 | INR 1500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 83

Pen and ink

8.3 x 8.8 inches | 21 × 22.3 cm

1970

GBP 4600 | INR 500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 78

Pen and ink

8 x 9 inches | 20.3 × 22.8 cm

1970

GBP 4600 | INR 500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 76

Pen and ink

7.5 x 7.5 inches | 19 × 19 cm

1970

GBP 4600 | INR 500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week

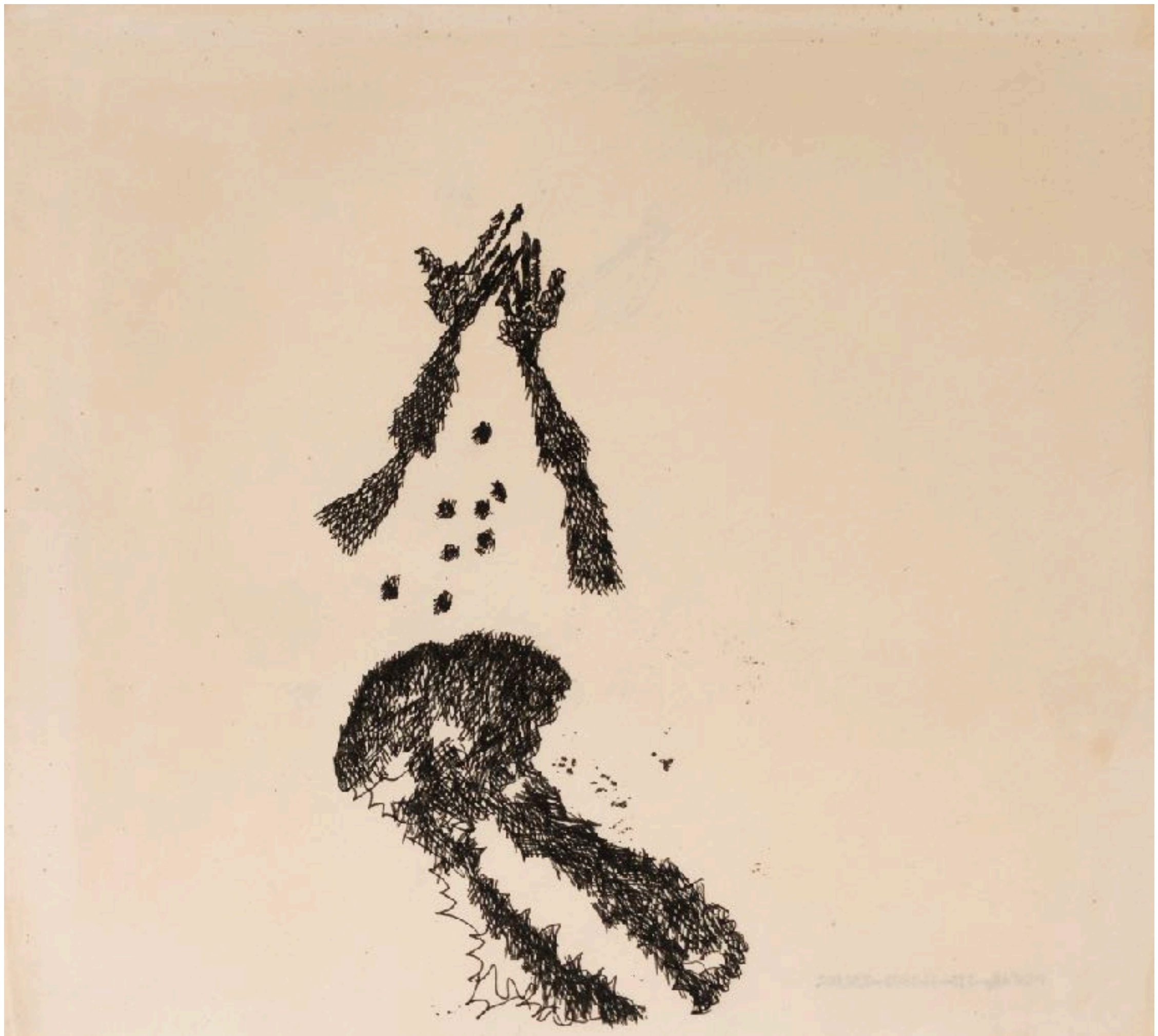


Amitava

Untitled 77
Pen and ink
8 x 6.8 inches | 20.3 × 17.2 cm
1970

GBP 4600 | INR 500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 79
Pen and ink
8.3 x 8.8 inches | 21 × 22.3 cm
1970

GBP 4600 | INR 500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 118
Ink and printing ink (cut-out)
14.1 x 20.2 inches | 35.8 × 51.3 cm
1970

GBP 9100 | INR 1000000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 19

Pen and ink on paper

13.5 x 9.5 inches | 34.2 × 24.1 cm

1970

GBP 9100 | INR 1000000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week

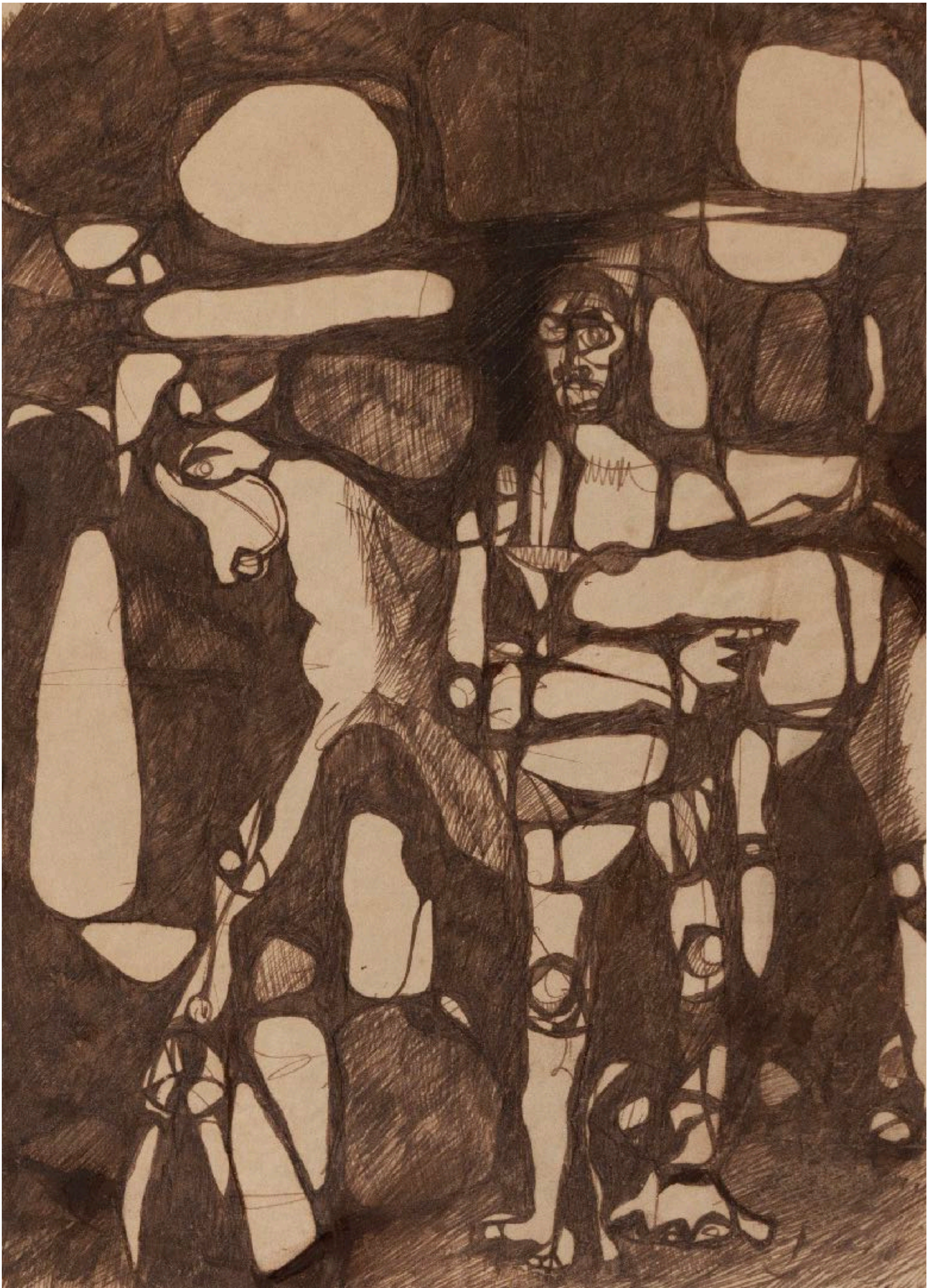


Amitava

Untitled 23
Pen and ink on paper
9 x 7.2 inches | 22.8 × 18.2 cm
1971

GBP 4600 | INR 500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 44
Sulekha brown ink on paper
12 x 9 inches | 30.4 × 22.8 cm
1970

GBP 6400 | INR 700000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 27

Pen and ink

13.5 x 9.5 inches | 34.2 × 24.1 cm

1970

GBP 7300 | INR 800000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 101

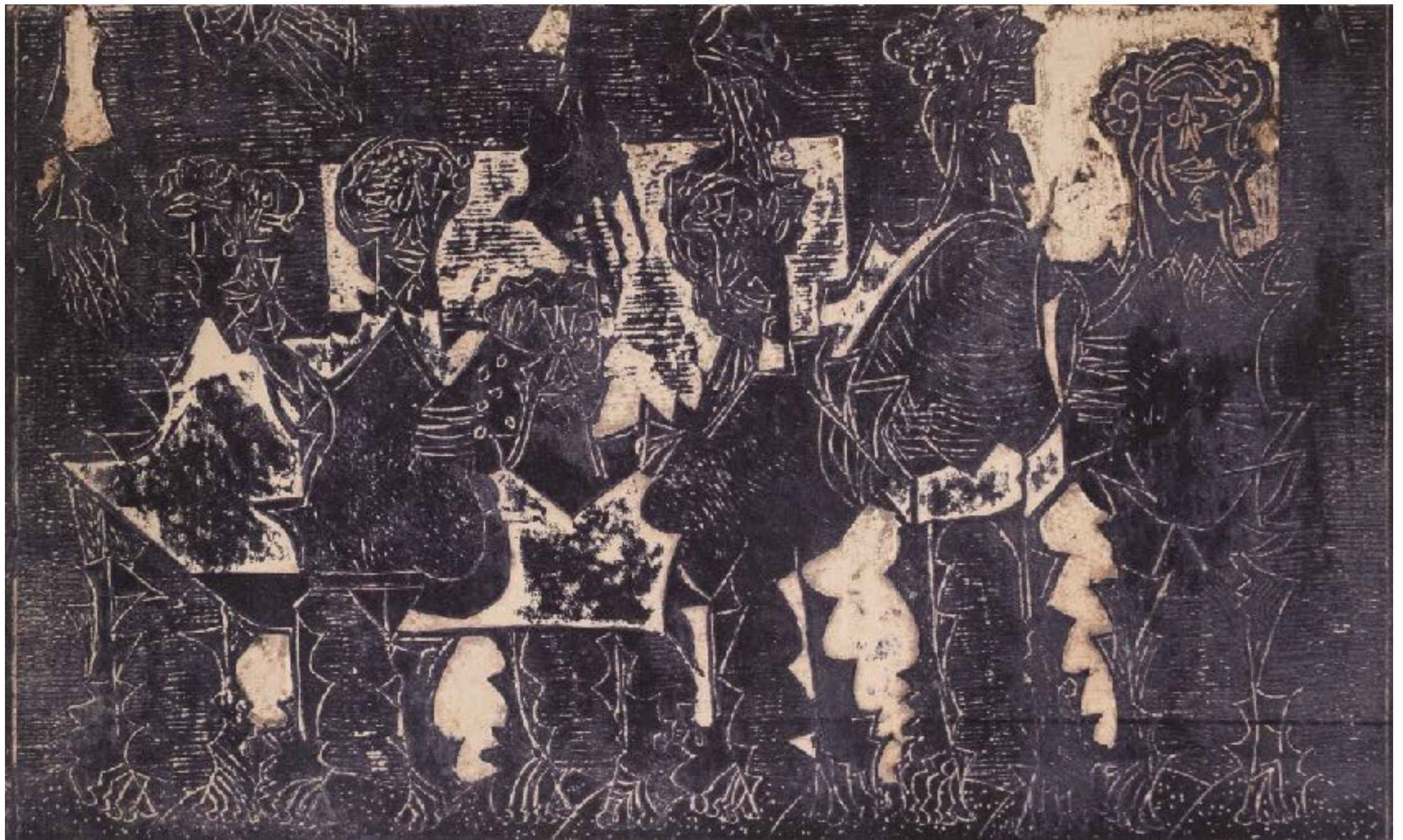
Oil on oil paper

14.3 x 11 inches | 36.3 × 27.9 cm

1970

GBP 10950 | INR 1200000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled 96
Mixed media
5.9 x 9.5 inches | 14.9 × 24.1 cm
1970

GBP 7300 | INR 800000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled

Oil on canvas

18 x 22 inches | 45.7 × 55.8 cm

1970

GBP 13650 | INR 1500000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week



Amitava

Untitled

Oil on canvas

18 x 22 inches | 45.7 × 55.8 cm

1970s

GBP 10950 | INR 1200000

*GBP rate applicable on the day of the sale if paid within the week

CV

Born

May 27 1947, New Delhi

Education

1965-72 College of Art, New Delhi

Teaching and Professional Experience

1974–1975 – Faculty, Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi

1977 – Visiting Faculty, College of Art and Women’s Polytechnic, New Delhi

1970s – Co-founder, The New Group, Delhi-based artists’ collective

1989 – Fellowship, Federal Republic of Germany (Advanced exposure to exhibition and graphic design)

Exhibitions

Selected Solo Exhibitions

2024

‘In Another Time That is Now’, Bikaner House, New Delhi

India Art Fair, Shrine Empire, New Delhi

2020

Old Bengal, Modern to Contemporary (Series – I), Gallery Kolkata, Calcutta

2019

Contemporary Practices, Gallery Kolkata

2010

Sakshi Gallery, Mumbai

2007

‘You Shall Remain Hidden...’, Selected Works on Paper from 1970 to 2007 by Amitava’, Gallery Espace, New Delhi
Anant Art, New Delhi

2004

Sakshi Gallery, Mumbai

1995

‘Works on Paper from 1972-94’, Sakshi Gallery, New Delhi

1990

Sakshi Gallery, Chennai

1989

‘Artists Alert’, New Delhi

1978

‘Works on Paper’, Dhoomimal Art Gallery, New Delhi

Selected Group Exhibitions

2025

India Art Fair, Shrine Empire, New Delhi

2024

If We Knew the Point, Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, New Delhi
Art Mumbai, Art Exposure, Mumbai
Miracle of Absence, Art Exposure, Kolkata
Old Bengal, Modern to Contemporary (Series I), Gallery Kolkata

2011

‘Melange’, The Harrington Street Arts Centre, Kolkata

2008

‘Frame Figure Field - 20th Century Modern and Contemporary Indian Art’, Delhi Art Gallery, New Delhi
‘Freedom: Sixty Years after Indian Independence’, Centre International Modern Art (CIMA), Kolkata

2007

‘Modern to Contemporary’, Gallery Kolkata, Kolkata
‘On Their Own: An Exhibition of Abstract Paintings’, Aakriti Art Gallery, Kolkata
‘Femina Power of Pink’, ITC Hotel, The Grand Central
‘Conglomeration’, Prakrit Arts, Chennai

2006

‘Making of Divinity’, Sakshi Gallery, Mumbai
‘Back to the Future’, Gallery Espace, New Delhi
‘The Naked Line: Drawings by 12 Artists’, Delhi Art Gallery, New Delhi

2005

‘Concept & Ideas’, Centre of International Modern Art (CIMA), Kolkata
‘Subtlety-Minimally’, presented by Sakshi Gallery, Mumbai at Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi

2001

‘The Human Factor’, The Guild, Mumbai

1999

‘Icons of the Millennium’, Lakeeren Gallery, Mumbai

1997

‘Through the Looking Glass’, Lakeeren Gallery, Mumbai

1995

‘View from the Edge’, Jehangir Art Gallery, Mumbai

1993

‘Indische Gegenwartskunst’, Mainz,Germany; Stettin, Poland
‘India Songs: Multiple Streams in Contemporary IndianArt’, New South Wales, Sydney

1992

‘Pioneer to the New Generation’, Arts Acre, West Bengal

1991

‘Three Contemporary Artists’, Bremen, Germany

1989

‘Contemporary Indian Painting’, Darmstadt, Germany

1977

‘Pictorial Space’, Ravindra Bhavan, Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi
‘Two Painters’, Black Partridge Gallery, New Delhi

1976

‘Twenty Artists’, Shridharani Gallery, New Delhi

1974-75

‘New Group’, Ravindra Bhavan, Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi & Jehangir Art Gallery, Mumbai

Participations

2011

‘Manifestations V’, Delhi Art Gallery, New Delhi
‘The Intuitive: Logic Revisted’, from the Osians Collection at The World Economic Forum, Davos, Switzerland

2010

Annual Exhibition, Chawla Art Gallery, New Delhi
‘Manifestations IV’, Delhi Art Gallery, New Delhi

2008

‘Zeitgenoessische Kunst aus Indien: Part II’, Galerie Müller & Plate, Munich
‘Annual Show’, Chawla Art Gallery, New Delhi

2007

‘Summer Show’, Centre International Modern Art (CIMA), Kolkata
Egyptian and Indian Painters at the Museum of Egyptian Modern Art, Museum of Modern Egyptian Art, Cairo
‘Harmony Show’, Nehru Centre, Mumbai

2006

Annual Show, Centre International Modern Art (CIMA), Kolkata

2003-04

‘The Dual Path of Indian Art Today: Part I’, Galerie Müller & Plate, Munich

1987

Bharat Bhavan Biennale, Bhopal

1979

‘All India Exhibition of Graphics’, Government Museum & Art Gallery, Chandigarh

1976

National Exhibition, Ravindra Bhavan, Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi

1971

‘Art Today III : Graphics & Drawings’, Ashoka Gallery, Kolkata

1970

‘Art Today II’, Ashoka Galley, Kolkata & Shridharani Art Gallery, New Delhi

1969

‘Art Today I’, Kunika Chemould, New Delhi

1968

Annual Exhibition, All India Fine Arts and Crafts Society (AIFACS), New Delhi

Honours and Awards

1989

Fellowship from the Federal Republic of Germany for the Advanced Exposure to the Exhibition and Graphic Design

1980-1982

All India Exhibition Prints, Chandigarh

1982

Sahitya Kala Parishad, New Delhi

1976

National Award, Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi

Film and Media Features

A Painter’s Portrait – documentary film by K. Bikram Singh for Doordarshan
Featured in various television programmes on contemporary Indian art

Design Projects

Has designed publications, exhibitions, interiors, furniture, and trade fair graphics

Collections (Selected)

National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi
Bharat Bhawan, Bhopal
Punjab Museum, Chandigarh
Lalit Kala Akademi, New Delhi
Contemporary Art Society, London

SHRINE EMPIRE

Anahita Taneja and Shefali Somani founded Shrine Empire in 2008. Since its inception, Shrine Empire has consistently focused on promoting artists from the South Asian region whose practices emphasize process, research, and conceptual use of media and material. The gallery’s programming has created a unique identity for the space through curated exhibitions and propositions, as well as commissioned projects which explore crossings between aesthetics and social/political concerns of its immediate context.

Shrine Empire’s community includes a large network of local and international partners, and in collaboration, the gallery contributes to building discourse on contemporary art in South Asia through discussions, artist talks, workshops and patronage. For the past several years, the gallery extended its outreach programs to build a strong base for the arts locally through sustained educational initiatives and by supporting alternative practices. The founders, who were recently awarded the Officier dans l’Ordre des Arts et des Lettres by the French government, consolidated their outreach initiatives under the not-for-profit Prameya Art Foundation [PRAF] in 2017.

art exposure

Art Exposure is a modern and contemporary art gallery based in Kolkata, India. Dedicated to advancing critical conversations around South Asian art, the gallery bridges historical practices with emerging voices. It showcases artists from modern masters to emerging talents, spanning generations and geographies.

In 2024, Art Exposure moved into a new 7,000 sq ft space, focused on promoting sustained and critical dialogues on modern and contemporary art practices. Alongside exhibitions, the gallery produces publications and catalogs that offer critical essays, scholarly writing, and archival insights - expanding global discourse and offering fresh perspectives on South Asia's rich artistic heritage.

For media inquiries, images, or to schedule interviews, please contact:

D 395 Defence Colony (Basement)
New Delhi-110024
P: +91 9654878785
E: info@shrineempiregallery.com
W: www.shrineempiregallery.com

16/2, Lake Terrace
Kolkata - 700029
P: +91 8697585015
E: srija@artexposure.in
W: www.artexposure.in

SHRINE EMPIRE

art exposure

